

SUCKAGE #4: LINDA'S BAD BREATH

I have people in my family who are life-long employees. I hear about their trials and toils. Despite two dozen different jobs over the years, I noticed nothing changes when it comes to office politics. It's the same story, different people, different day, in a different office. So-and-so is sleeping with the boss and courting favor. Jim is lazy but takes credit for the work. Linda has bad breath and everyone is afraid to tell her. Lacey arrives late and leaves early. Horace steals food and wears the same sport jacket every day. Lazy Lester never replaces the copier paper. Same stories, different office.

No matter where you work, office politics play a part. The stage is different but the actors are the same. And, unfortunately, as an employee immersed in the work environment, you have to play the game. You have to be obedient or face retribution from coworkers or your boss.

I can remember my friend's after-work rants as she toiled at a high-carbohydrate corporate environment. Everything had a process. Got an idea? Great, send it to the boss, the boss sends it to his boss, who then hands it off to legal, who then sends it back to her boss's boss for revisions, who sends it back, blah blah blah! By the time the "idea" gets anywhere it's either stale or four other people have staked a claim to it. Who needs this entangled web destroying your sanity? The only defense to office politics is to control the playing field, and to do that, you have to be the boss. And to be the boss, you not only need to run the show, you need to own it.

SUCKAGE #5: A SUBSCRIPTION TO "PAY YOURSELF LAST"

"Pay yourself first" is a Slowlane doctrine. The problem is that it's near impossible in a job. Local, state, and federal governments heavily tax earned income and your options to shield that income from taxation is limited to contributions to 401KS and IRAS—which are also limited—10% of your income or a maximum of \$16,500, whichever is less. If you diligently trade your life and ascend into corporate management, expect 50% of your money to disappear before it touches your hands. As an employee, you immediately receive a subscription to "pay yourself last," and yes, that subscription arrives even if you don't subscribe. If you are paying yourself last and everyone gets your money first, don't expect to build wealth fast.

SUCKAGE #6: A DICTATORSHIP ON INCOME

Ever get hit with a 1,000% pay raise from your boss? Imagine this: Impressed at the obvious returns you've provided at your job, you confidently stroll into your boss's office and demand a raise. "I bring value to this company," you argue. "I'm reliable and rarely call in sick."

Your boss takes a defensive posture, crosses his arms, tilts his head skyward, and leisurely reclines in his big, red executive chair. You take a deep breath and let it ride. "Therefore, sir, I'd like a 1,000% pay raise."